La Primavera di Firenze

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COL-2030509

APPLe: Hmm ...

APPLe: This is most confusing.

APPLe: Almost every fresco has one of these humanoid symbols, each adopting a different pose.

Sotheby: I once read something similar in a detective story. It could be a secret code used between close friends to encrypt their conversation. Like Typhon and Orthrus!

Leonardo: Orthrus? You mean this might be an encrypted version of Ancient Greek? The grammar doesn't seem to match.

Leonardo: Hmm?

Leonardo suddenly turns the pages, slamming his finger on his new discovery.

Sotheby: Mister Leonardo! We haven't finished! Do you mind?

Leonardo: Uccello ...

Leonardo: It's Paolo Uccello!

Leonardo: The copies cannot recreate every detail of the originals, but still the style makes it self-evident: the perspective is perfect, and the geometric figures are so precise that it almost starts to get dull ...

Leonardo: There's no doubt this is Paolo Uccello's work!

Ezio: ...

Vertin: What's wrong, Ezio?

Ezio: I know the name. My mother used to be a patron of his.

All: What?!

Ezio: I was young when we met. All I remember is that he was a shy man who kept his head low as he worked.

Ezio: He left before what happened to my family, then we lost touch ...

The assassin lets his eyes rest on the flickering candlelight in the corner.

Ezio: I haven't seen him since.

Leonardo: Ezio's mother, La Signora Maria Auditore, is a kindhearted patrona. She has sponsored many artists, myself included.

Leonardo: I never expected Uccello to be involved. Though, I've heard he was a strange man.

Leonardo: He became obsessed with his studies on perspective; then eventually he disappeared. Not even his family knew where he went.

Leonardo: It was declared that he died sometime ago—1475, I believe. But some claim that he is still alive, still painting, scratching out a living somewhere far from civilization.

Ezio: Hold on. Take a look at the lines in the other frescoes. This bird, its lines are rougher than Uccello's. These were drawn by someone else—an imitator.

Leonardo: You're right ... This is a counterfeit!

APPLe: This APPLe hadn't expected an assassin to be so cultured, Ezio.

Leonardo pats Ezio on the shoulder, smiling.

Leonardo: Don't be fooled by his rough exterior, sir! The Auditores were once one of the great families of Firenze. Not so powerful as the Medicis, but still ...

Ezio: Ahem.

Ezio only responds with a few coughs, indicating the topic should shift.

Ezio: As Leonardo said, my mother has been a patron of many artists, including Uccello. I've seen his work many times on the walls of our home in Monteriggioni.

Leonardo: Hmm? This is ...

Leonardo jumps up, looking particularly serious.

Leonardo: Ladies and gentlemen, I believe I may have discovered the location of the hidden chamber.

Sotheby: Goodness me ... You figured that out before I could even finish the manuscript.

Leonardo: I'm sorry, my lady. Once I begin, it is hard to stop the mechanisms of my mind.

Leonardo straightens out his hair, looking somewhat bashful.

Leonardo: Take a look.

Leonardo: It's a copy of the dome's blueprint! I've never seen anything so perfect in its design ...

Leonardo: The design was inspired by the Pantheon, and Brunelleschi invented the double-layer dome on that basis.

APPLe: What a genius idea! The two shells serve as a buttress to each other so that the dome could avoid from collapsing even at this size.

Leonardo: Precisely! But see here the tunnel between the two shells is scarcely wide enough for a man to fit through. That is except for this space below the ribs.

Vertin: Which means the secret chamber has to be there.

Leonardo: Exactly! But it's no more than an inference for now. We must visit Il Duomo to confirm it for ourselves.

Leonardo: Ezio, you're familiar with the structure, aren't you? You've been beneath its catacombs.

Ezio: I am. I have.

Ezio: But the Cathedral will be under careful watch by the Templars. I doubt we can slip in undetected.

Ezio: We need another way in.

Leonardo: Don't worry. I have already devised a way.

Leonardo winks and smiles, which suggests a surprise.

Leonardo: Have you heard of my work there, the Assumption of Mary?

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Sotheby: Two vanishing points, huh ...? I wonder if a painting can have three, four, or an infinite number of vanishing points!

Sotheby: Wait, I guess they would get all tangled and messed up that way. What was I thinking?

Leonardo: Multiple vanishing points ... waning sanctuaries ... EUREKA!

Leonardo: I can't believe I didn't think of it sooner! If the whole thing is connected to Paolo Uccello, then of course linear perspective would be crucial for solving the riddle!

He turns around, excitement gleaming in his eyes as he looks at his two bewildered companions.

Leonardo: Do you still remember the riddle? "Under the waning glow, the waning sanctuaries unite."

Vertin: Could "waning sanctuaries" be his way of saying "vanishing points"?

Leonardo: Yes, I believe so! Following this logic, then for them to "unite" must refer to the intersection of the lines extending from the vanishing points, and "waning glow" naturally must refer to the setting sun!

He raises his brush, pointing toward the window.

Leonardo: In other words, we need to find the intersection of the vanishing points before the sun sets!

Vertin: But the riddle didn't specify which painting, did it?

Leonardo: It must be a fresco right outside the secret chamber. Rumors say the secret chamber's switch is hidden within a mysterious fresco.

Leonardo: A fresco often consists of multiple sections. If all of them employ linear perspective ...

Sotheby: Then there will be a lot of vanishing points to follow!

The sound of the bells tolling reverberates through the building, mingling with the rising smoke from a nearby censer.

Leonardo: By the bells, it must be five already. We must hurry and inform Ezio of our discovery.

Leonardo: We won't be able to solve the riddle once night falls. Time is of the essence.

Sotheby: Uh-huh, then it's time we take action!

Sotheby: Mr. Leonardo, please stay here and keep Father Alberto busy while Vertin and I inform Mr. APPLe about ...

The fog from the censer thickens.

Sotheby: Hmm? Where have these clouds ... come from? I feel like ... I could use some shut-eye right now ...

Leonardo: No, this isn't time to ... sleep ... We must ... find ...

Leonardo: Wait, what are we ... trying to find ...?

Sotheby: I-It's sleeping gas ... Cover your nose ... hurry ...

The two lean on each other but soon collapse to the floor together.

Vertin: Sotheby! Leonardo!

Vertin: Not good. This fog is getting thicker by the second ...

She scrambles to get away but soon falls to the floor with the others.

After an unknown amount of time, soft footsteps echo in the darkness.

Alberto: Leonardo? What's going on here? Have you fallen asleep?

Their silence is a silent affirmation.

Alberto: Keep on sleeping, poor lambs ... and may you have sweet dreams.

Alberto: May the Father of Understanding guide us.

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The vanishing points, hidden beneath layers of lime plaster and pigments, finally merge in the waning sunlight.

The only thing left to do is lift APPLe up and wait—

For the perfect ray of light.

The light, here it comes.

Outside, the bells ring out, startling a flock of rock doves.

As twilight streams down over the fresco, the once drab surface begins to change color …

Uccello: Let's leave something behind for our own sake! Birds with grayish feathers, bells that ring at dusk, or the Arno River running free …

Uccello: Let's do it! With all that we have left!

Uccello: Our brushes and pigments!

Ezio: … So that is what all of this is.

Just a group of artists who cast aside all constraints to finish a masterpiece in secret.

No linear perspective, no intricate designs—yet a masterpiece nonetheless.

They left behind a magnificent spring for Florence.